

1560–1590

ELEGANT FORMALITY

As the century progressed so the gradual stiffening of women's dress continued. The increasingly rigid garments began to need extra support, and separate boned "pairs of bodies" (stiff undergarments) worn under gowns started to appear – the beginning of stays and corsetry. Linear bands and braids followed the clothing's sharp lines and emphasized its control of body shape. The body's natural lines rarely appeared. The rise and power of the Spanish empire made their severe formality and clever tailoring fashionable, although in many Italian areas a more relaxed soft look held sway. Ruffs slowly widened and became separate from shirt collars. Labour-intensive lace made its first appearance and became a mark of luxury – similar to velvets or jewels. Necklines were either at bust level or up to the chin. The silhouette stayed triangular with narrow waists ending in sharp points and full skirts. The tops of sleeves of women's dresses started to be styled into puffs, tabs, and rolls. Male and female fashions followed similar trends of adornments, cut, and colour.

ACCESSORIES

The 16th century saw an increase in the variety and adornment of accessories for both men and women. Gloves, made of the finest leather, could be embroidered, and were given as tokens of respect and affection. Fans were popular in hot countries. Linen handkerchiefs were a splendid way to show off the new techniques of needle- and bobbin-lace. When shoes became visible, their heels and rosettes became equally decorative. Silk and gold ribbons, used in abundance if possible, were also a form of accessory because of their high price.

Embroidered gloves

Feathered Italian fan



Softer lines This Venetian bride's bodice is rigid and pointed, but her skirt, sleeves, and posture are softer and more relaxed than northern European fashions. Venetian women wore chopines (platform shoes with cork soles) for extra height.

Spanish saya In the 1570s Anna of Austria, Queen of Spain, wore an elegant black saya (gown) with white accents and lavish embroidery. The gown's long, pointed sleeves and subtle fit earned Spanish tailors international repute.



High collar with small ruff

Doublet worn underneath

Silver and gold embroidery

Fashionably blonde hair

Oriental-style veil

Low neckline with open partlet

Jewelled aiglets (ribbon tips) with silk ribbons

Handkerchief edged with needle lace